

Socioeconomic Barriers to Educational Access in Lagos

Introduction

In 2013, one in every five of the world's out-of-school children was in Nigeria. That number has nearly doubled to date, with twenty million children aged 5-14 years out of school (UNICEF Nigeria, 2024). This issue is compounded by low literacy rates—only 49% of children in school achieve basic literacy proficiency, and 55% achieve basic numeracy proficiency ("UNICEF Statistics On Education In Nigeria Infographic," 2024). Poverty also plays a significant role; on average, four out of ten individuals in Nigeria have real per capita expenditures below 137,430 Naira (\$85) per year (National Bureau of Statistics, 2019). Insecurity and corruption further exacerbate these conditions, ensuring that those in poverty have limited opportunities for upward mobility. Access to quality education is a fundamental right and a key driver of socioeconomic development (World Bank, 2023). To understand further, we interviewed Tyro and Ibrahim, two young boys currently out of school in Lagos. They expressed difficulty in going to school due to financial hardships and the loss of their primary breadwinners- their fathers (M. Tyro, personal communication, Feb 23, 2025; A. Ibrahim, personal communication, Feb 23, 2025).

Challenge Landscape

There are significant disparities in access to quality education in Lagos. This is due to economic barriers and high levels of socioeconomic inequality, cultural practices and beliefs, and the severe underfunding of the educational sector.

Poverty: The quality of education children receive largely depends on their parents' financial capacity. Private schools are expensive, while public schools suffer from underfunding (National Bureau of Statistics, 2019). In 2019, 40.1% of Nigeria's total population was classified as poor. Many families struggle to afford basic necessities such as food, shelter, and clothing, forcing children to engage in child labor or informal trade instead of attending school (National Bureau of Statistics & International Labour Organization, 2024).

Cultural Barriers: In some regions, cultural biases favor child labor and early marriage over formal education, particularly for girls (Teach for Nigeria, 2023). Some religious leaders and communities view Western-style education with suspicion, associating it with the erosion of local cultural and religious values (Slum2School, 2024).

Underfunding of the Educational System: Nigeria allocates less than 10% of its national budget to education—well below the UNESCO-recommended 15-20% (United Nations Children's Fund, 2023). These limited funds are further reduced due to corruption, including bribes, embezzlement, and favoritism in fund allocation (Transparency International, 2023). Many schools lack basic infrastructure such as classrooms, furniture, and sanitation, and there is a critical shortage of teachers (Punch NG, 2023). Additionally, school locations present a geographical barrier, as long commutes deter students from attending school, particularly in rural areas (Effiong & Okijie, 2022).

Stakeholders

- Students
- Teachers
- Families
- Entrepreneurs
- On-the-ground NGOs
- Think tanks
- International organizations
- Private schools
- Public schools
- Community Leaders
- Government officials

Existing Solutions

Government Initiatives: The Nigerian government has implemented several policies aimed at improving educational access. The Universal Basic Education Act (UBE) mandates free and compulsory education, though weak enforcement and chronic underfunding limit its effectiveness (Universal Basic Education Act, 2004). The Conditional Cash Transfer Program (CCTP) provides financial aid to families who keep their children in school, though its reach remains restricted due to funding limitations (World Bank, 2023). Similarly, the National Social Investment Program (NISIP) supports education and poverty alleviation efforts, but its long-term sustainability remains uncertain (Global Partnership for Education, 2023). In an effort to combat corruption, Nigeria introduced the Corrupt Practices and Other Related Offences Act (2000) and the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission (Establishment) Act (2004), yet mismanagement of educational funds persists (Transparency International, 2023).

Individual Efforts: Families play a critical role in ensuring children's education, often working multiple jobs to cover school expenses. However, many children are still forced into labor due to financial pressures. Teachers, despite low wages and poor conditions, continue to educate students at personal financial sacrifice (Teach for Nigeria, 2023). Nigeria's national curriculum, regulated by the Nigerian Educational Research and Development Council (NERDC), is outdated and does not reflect local economic needs, contributing to low engagement and dropout rates (Nigerian Educational Research and Development Council, n.d.).

International Organizations & NGOs: International organizations and NGOs provide financial aid, policy support, and grassroots interventions. The World Bank's BESDA program funds state-led education reforms, while the Global Partnership for Education (GPE) supports policy planning and infrastructure development, though corruption limits impact (World Bank, 2023). The UNODC Strategic Vision for Nigeria 2030 includes education as part of crime prevention (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, 2021), while the Education Cannot Wait (ECW) initiative focuses on emergency education for displaced children. Grassroots organizations like Bridge International Academies, Slum2School, and Teach for Nigeria provide low-cost education, scholarships, and teacher training (Bridge International Academies, n.d.; Slum2School, 2024).

Proposed Interventions

To improve government efforts, stricter legal enforcement should hold parents accountable for children's education, while increased budget allocation would enhance school infrastructure, teacher salaries, and resources. Expanding conditional cash transfers through a landscape analysis would support more at-risk families, and remote learning models could ensure education continuity in crisis-prone areas. Additionally, Nigeria should digitalize learning, shifting from one-to-one to one-to-many teaching models, and establish contract-based agreements, such as five-year minimum contracts, to retain teachers. Curriculum reforms should incorporate regionally relevant and culturally adaptive content to increase engagement and reduce dropout rates, while expanding NGO and EdTech partnerships would further improve teacher training and student outcomes.

For better accountability in international aid, funding should be directed to NGOs rather than government intermediaries, with blockchain-based financial tracking ensuring transparency. National education landscape analyses could help identify underserved areas and redirect resources effectively. Reducing financial barriers requires subsidized healthcare, food vouchers, and tax benefits for parents who send their children to school, alongside expanding vocational training programs to provide alternative pathways for children from impoverished backgrounds.

Lastly, cultural barriers should be addressed through collaboration with religious and community leaders to promote education's value, while culturally relevant curricula and digital learning initiatives can bridge educational gaps caused by social and geographic challenges.

Bibliography

- Bloom, D. E., & Sachs, J. (1998). Geography, demography, and economic growth in Africa. *Brookings Papers on Economic Activity*.
- Bridge International Academies. (n.d.). *About Bridge International Academies*. Bridge International Academies.
<https://www.bridgeinternationalacademies.com>
- Brookings Institution. (n.d.). *Poverty, inequality, and Africa's education crisis*.
<https://www.brookings.edu/articles/poverty-inequality-and-africas-education-crisis/>
- Effiong, U., & Okijie, S. (2022). Rural-urban polarization and the sustainable development of rural communities in Nigeria. *GPH-International Journal of Social Science and Humanities Research*, 5(4), 65-81.
<https://www.gphjournal.org/index.php/ssh/article/view/591>
- e-Learning Infographics. (2024). *UNICEF statistics on education in Nigeria infographic*.
<https://elearninginfographics.com/unicef-statistics-on-education-in-nigeria-infographic/>
- Global Partnership for Education. (2023). *GPE in Nigeria*. Global Partnership for Education.
<https://www.globalpartnership.org/where-we-work/nigeria>
- Michalopoulos, S., & Papaioannou, E. (2016). The long-run effects of the scramble for Africa. *American Economic Review*.
- National Bureau of Statistics. (2019). *Poverty and inequality in Nigeria: Executive summary*. National Bureau of Statistics. <https://www.nigerianstat.gov.ng>
- National Bureau of Statistics & International Labour Organization. (2024). *Nigeria child labour and forced labour survey 2022*. International Labour Office.
https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/2024-04/Nigeria_Child_Labour_Survey_2022_Report_WEB.pdf
- Nigerian Educational Research and Development Council. (n.d.). *National curriculum framework*. Nigerian Educational Research and Development Council. <https://www.nerdc.org.ng>
- Nunn, N. (2008). *The long-term effects of Africa's slave trade*.
- Nunn, N., & Wantchekon, L. (2011). *The slave trade and the origins of mistrust in Africa*.
- Punch NG. (2023, January 31). *Nigeria rises five places in 2023 corruption perception index*. *The Punch Newspaper*. <https://punchng.com/nigeria-rises-five-places-in-2023-corruption-perception-index/>

ResearchGate. (2018). *Nigeria's rural-urban literacy rate in 2018*.

https://www.researchgate.net/figure/Nigerias-rural-urban-literacy-rate-in-2018_tbl1_360458103

Slum2School. (2024). *Bridging the education gap for underserved children in Nigeria*. Slum2School.

<https://www.slum2school.org>

StateUniversity.com. (n.d.). *Nigeria - Educational system—Overview*.

<https://education.stateuniversity.com/pages/1125/Nigeria-EDUCATIONAL-SYSTEM.html>

Statista. (n.d.). *Education in Nigeria - Statistics & facts*. <https://www.statista.com/topics/6687/education-in-nigeria/>

Teach for Nigeria. (2023). *Transforming education through leadership*. Teach for Nigeria.

<https://www.teachfornigeria.org>

Transparency International. (2023). *Corruption perceptions index 2023*. Transparency International.

<https://www.transparency.org/en/countries/nigeria>

UNICEF Nigeria. (2024). *Education*. UNICEF. <https://www.unicef.org/nigeria/education>

United Nations Children's Fund. (2023). *Education in Nigeria: A crisis in learning*. UNICEF.

<https://www.unicef.org/nigeria/education>

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2021). *Strategic vision for Nigeria 2030: Addressing crime, justice, and education reform*. United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. <https://www.unodc.org/nigeria>

Universal Basic Education Act. (2004). *Universal Basic Education Act 2004*. Universal Basic Education Commission. <https://ubec.gov.ng/wp-content/uploads/2021/09/NGA87623-UBE-ACT-2004.pdf>

World Bank. (2023). *Better education service delivery for all (BESDA) program: Education reform in Nigeria*.

World Bank. <https://www.worldbank.org/en/country/nigeria/project/education>